

The first 90 seconds

You are awake and it is the middle of the night. Do these five things before you decide anything about the night. Nothing here needs a screen.

1 Do not look at the clock

Not once. The number changes nothing you are about to do, and it is what starts the arithmetic that wakes you up properly.

2 Let the jaw come apart

Teeth not touching, tongue away from the roof of the mouth. Shoulders down, hands open.

3 Breathe out longer than you breathe in

In through the nose for four, hold for seven, out through the mouth for eight. Three rounds. The long exhale is the part that lowers the alarm.

4 Say the line

I am not trying to sleep. I am resting until it comes back. Trying is the pressure that keeps you awake.

5 Then check one thing: heavy or wired

Not whether you are asleep. Only how the body feels.

HEAVY

Stay in bed. Eyes want to stay closed, limbs feel far away, thoughts have gone loose. Let the night happen without supervision.

WIRED

Get up after about 20 minutes. Chest fast, mind in full sentences, lying at attention. Leaving the bed is what stops the bed from becoming the place where you lie awake.

If you get up

- **Low light only.** No overhead light, no bright screen.
- **A chair, not the bed and not the sofa.** Something over your shoulders.
- **Write the loop out on paper.** Then one line: the smallest thing you will do about it tomorrow.
- **Read something boring.** On paper if you have it. Not news, not messages.
- **Go back when your eyes close on their own,** not when you feel you have waited long enough.

Tomorrow, which matters more

- **Normal wake time.** Not later, not on the weekend either.
- **Ten minutes of outdoor light** in the first half hour up.
- **No nap,** or twenty minutes before 3pm at the most.
- **Caffeine as usual in the morning,** none after midday.
- **Same bedtime tonight,** or later. Going to bed early to catch up is what turns one bad night into a bad week.

One night awake does not undo the week. What repeats the pattern is the morning after, not the night itself.